

From Consensus to Divergence

Generational shifts in civic tolerance

UNITED STATES • 1972-2024

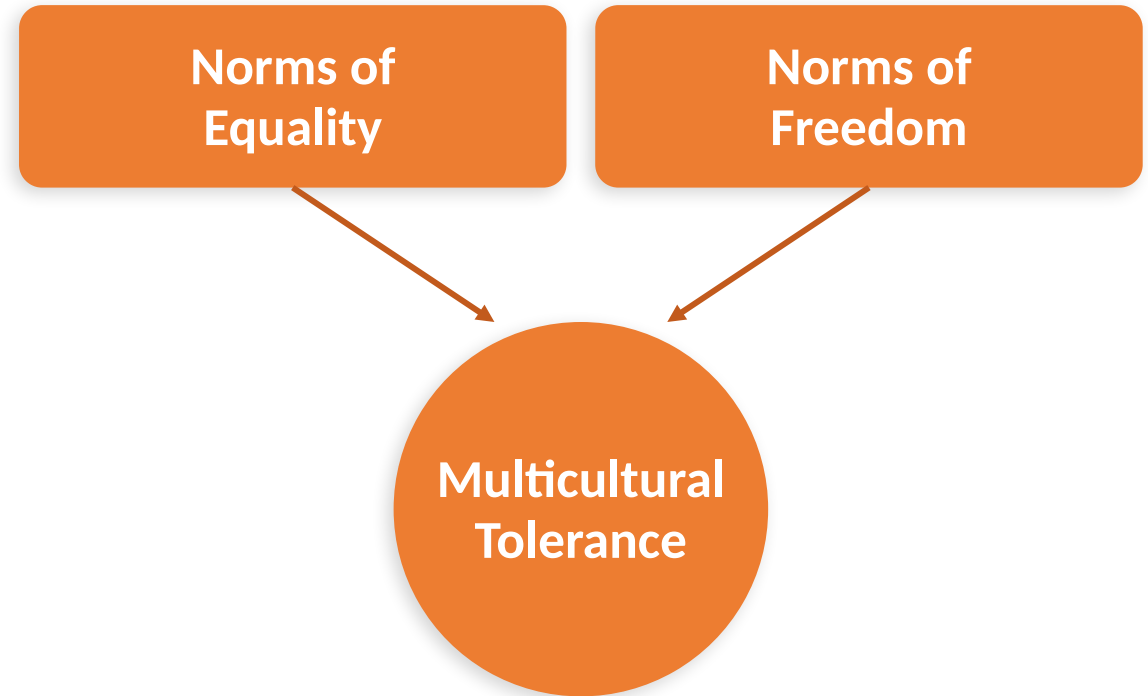
DATA & METHOD

U.S. General Social Survey, 1972-2024. Cohort comparison from the Greatest Generation through Gen Z.

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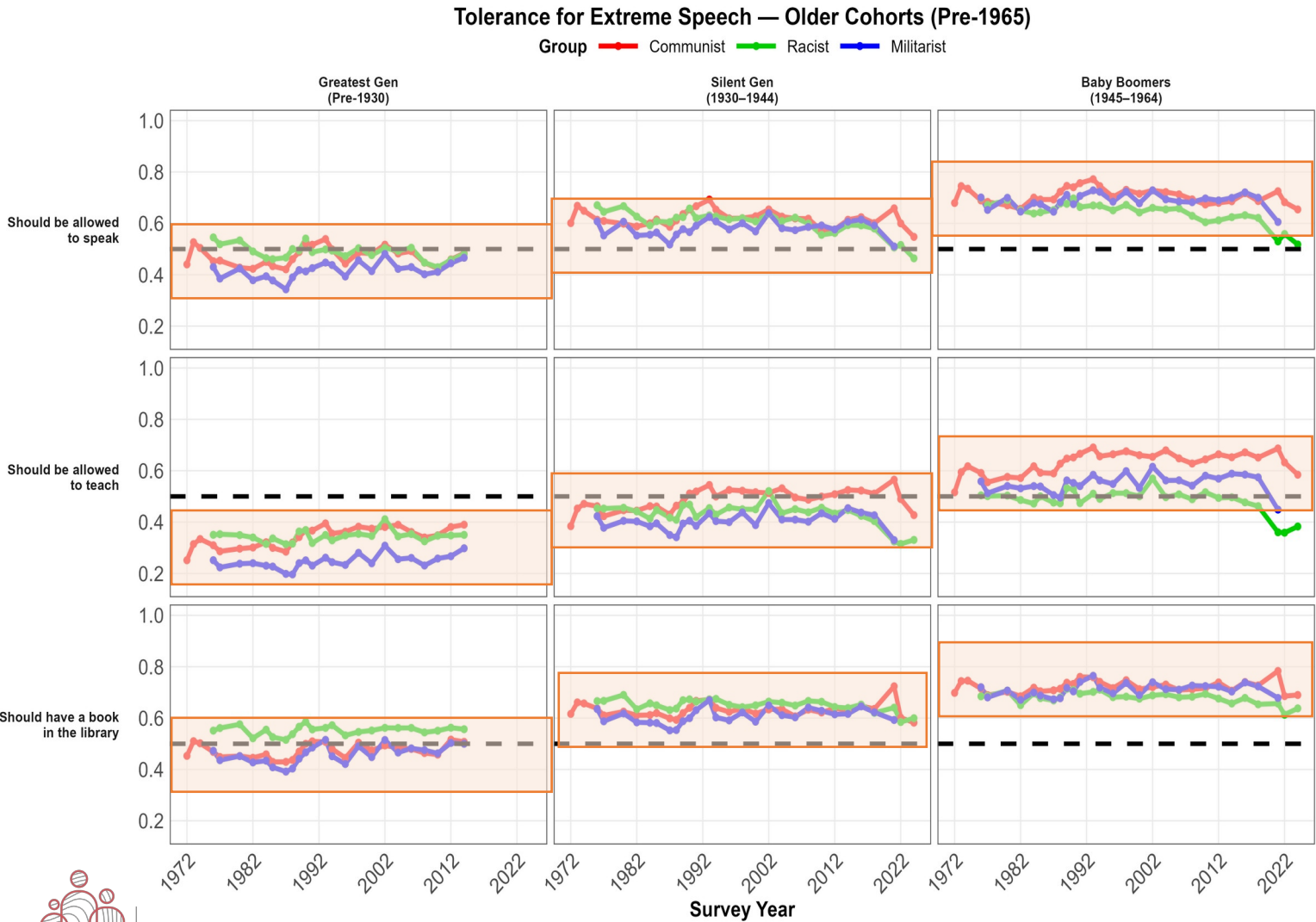
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WHAT IS HAPPENING?

Younger generations increasingly filter free-speech tolerance through the potential harm of that speech to marginalized communities > “multicultural” tolerance.

Tolerance rose across the board



All three target groups — communists, racists, militarists — trend upward together from the Greatest Generation to the Baby Boomers.

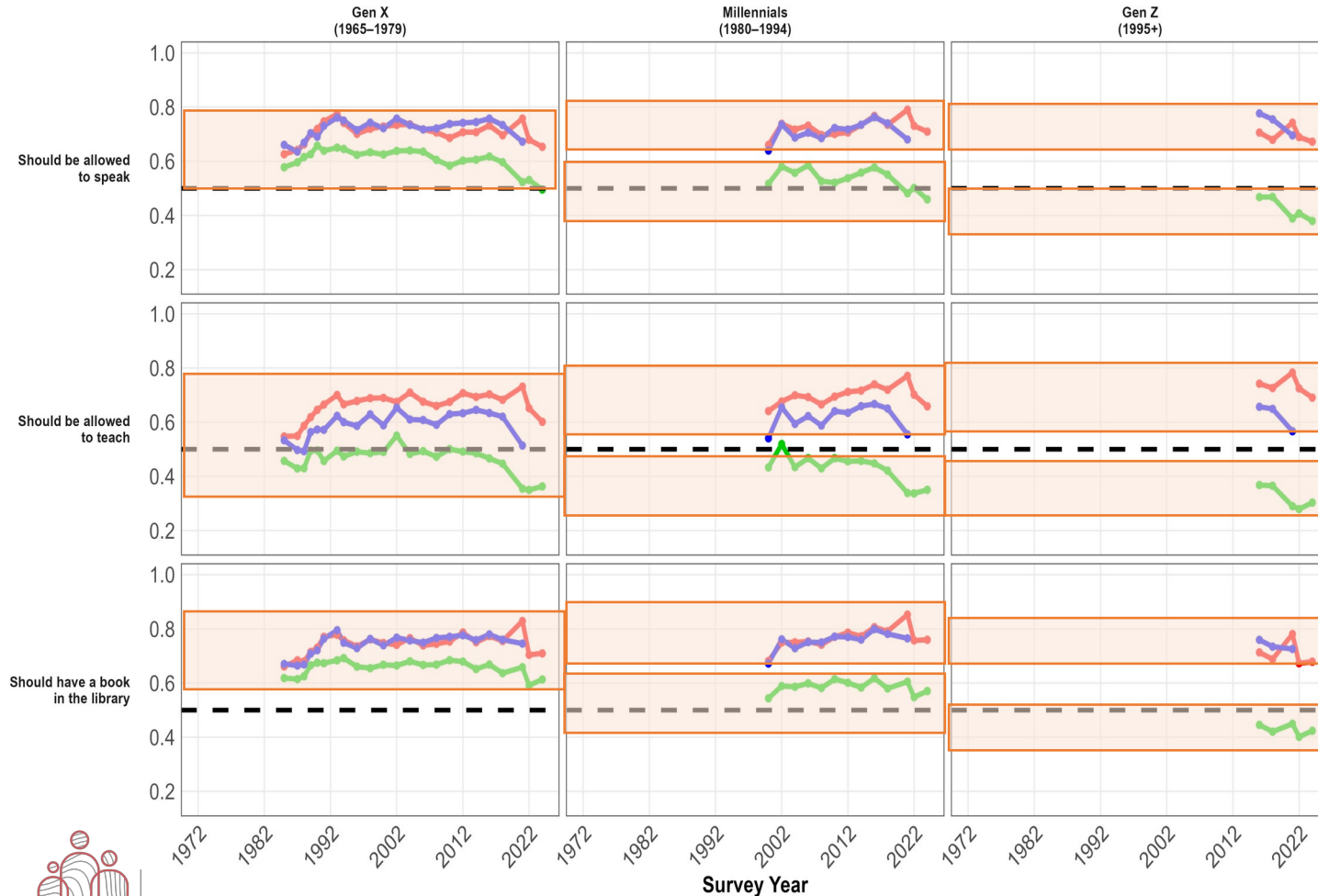
↑ OVERALL INCREASE

Little divergence between groups: tolerance is broadly uniform across targets.

Tolerance splits — tolerance for racists declines

Tolerance for Extreme Speech — Younger Cohorts (1965+)

Group — Communist (red line), Racist (green line), Militarist (blue line)



Data: GSS 1972–2024

THE DIVERGENCE

Tolerance for communists and militarists stays high; but tolerance for racists drops among younger cohorts.



DIVERGENCE



IMPLICATIONS

- Politically fringe ideals are now being filtered through the lens of multicultural tolerance.
- Cohort replacement might indicate future changes in norms. For future studies, we need to see the bounds of this selective approach to tolerance of civil liberties for younger cohorts and whether it creates division in public support for pro-civil liberties policies in the US.

— — Dashed line = 50% tolerance threshold.

Data: U.S. GSS, 1972–2024



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